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Critical Political Economy of Facebook: Digital Labour Exploitation in Social Media[*]

Facebook'un Eleştirel Ekonomi Politiği: Sosyal Medyada Dijital Emek Sömürüsü

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Abstract: Meta Platforms, the owner of Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, is the world's largest social media company. The revenue model of social media companies is based on targeted advertising. In this type of advertising, the likes left by the us er on social media and all kinds of data are sold to marketing companies as commodities. Users are expected to devote all their time and attention to the platform. The more users and time spent on the platform, the more user attention and data can be harvested, which is the prerequisite for social media companies to accumulate capital. Privacy policies have secured the collection of data. To avoid giving up on the gains provided by social media, users often ignore or never read what is written in the privacy policy so as not to waste time. Thus, they consent to their data being sold to marketing companies. Users produce and consume social media content themselves. They spend considerable time and labour doing that. However, users never get paid for that. Also, their data is sold to marketing companies as commodities. That is called digital labour exploitation. Social media platforms are free in theory, yet the exploitation of the users is the price to be paid in practice. This study aims to explain the exploitation of digital labour, characterized by unpaid user labour and data in social media. In the theoretical part of the study, the exploitation of digital labour was examined based on Facebook's capital accumulation model. A field study was conducted to identify the approach and awareness of social media users in Turkey on digital labour exploitation. It concluded that users were not highly aware of digital labour exploitation. It was determined that many users prefer to keep using these social media despite the exploitation in these platforms.

Structured Abstract: Based on market capitalization, there are five new media giant companies: Apple, Microsoft, Google, Amazon, and Facebook. Among these five companies, Facebook differs from the other companies because, it does not produce any hardware or software The only thing Facebook sells to its customers is advertising. In his Facebook status updates and interviews, -the owner of Facebook- Mark Zuckerberg, often puts similar emphasis on "sociality", "social benefit", "connecting people", and

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"goodness". In doing so, Zuckerberg tried to show that the main thing that matters for Facebook is a social benefit, not money. However, between 2007 and 2016, Facebook got into trouble with privacy violations and democracy interference. Changing its name to Meta Platforms in 2021 (Isaac, 2021), Facebook has evolved from a small social network on the Harvard University campus in 16 years into an oligopoly in the technology industry. Nowadays, Facebook has 2.91 billion users, and Facebook-owned Instagram has approximately 1.5 billion users. These figures make Facebook the world's largest social media company (Kemp, 2022). Today Thus, it has been understood that the purpose of Facebook, which has grown and prospered, is to become a monopoly in the social media industry rather than connecting humanity by means of social benefit.

Growing with acquisitions, monopolizing vertically and horizontally, and increasing the number of its users since the day it was founded, Facebook multiplied its revenues (McCain, 2022). Facebook has achieved this by harvesting its users' content, data, and attention. According to critical communication sciences theorisian Christian Fuchs (2014; 2017), Facebook has grown and prospered by exploiting the users' unpaid labour-time. Fuchs calls it digital labour exploitation.

This study aims to reveal how the exploitation of digital labour, characterized by unpaid prosumers' labour time, is carried out on Facebook and all social media platforms. The other purpose of the study is to determine the attitudes, awareness and tendencies of social media platform users in Turkey against digital labour exploitation by social media companies through field study. This study aims to theoretically and practically conduct an integrated and inclusive research of Turkey's most used social media platform users. When the Turkish communication literature is scanned, it is seen that there is a lack of comprehensive field research on the exploitation of digital labour in social media platforms. In this respect, the study is significant as it aims to fill the practical gap in the country's communication literature with extensive field research.

Conceptual and Theoretical Framework: The critical political economy of communication has particular importance in critical communication theories as it can handle mass media and new media from an integrated perspective. Dallas Smythe was one of the pioneers of critical political economy of communication in 1970s-1980s. According to Smythe (1977), all the time except when we sleep is working time in capitalism. A significant proportion of non-business work time is audience time sold to advertisers. Workers perform marketing functions for those who market the products in this time slot, which the audience owns. Thus, they happen to rework the production and reproduction of labour power. Media content is a "free lunch " to keep audience engaged. With this approach, Smythe introduced the concept of "the audience commodity ". According to Smythe, in the ratings-based advertising type of TV, the audience is sold to advertisers as a commodity. The audience donates unpaid labour time and receives TV show content and advertising in return. Fuchs (2014) adopted this concept to social media.

Social media companies sell users' data commodities to marketing companies or advertising publishers for a price higher than the fixed and variable capital invested. The surplus value available in this sold commodity is partly created by users and partly by employees of social media companies. Users are more exploited as users are not paid, whereas employees are paid. When the prosumer data commodity is sold to the advertising customer, the commodity turns into money; surplus value turns into capital. According to Marxist theory, this is exploitation, as social media users are not paid for the content produced. This accumulation strategy pursued by social media companies is to provide users with free access to services and platforms, to allow them to produce content, and to accumulate as many prosumers as possible that can be sold as commodities to advertisers (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 199).

On social media platforms users create and review content by spending digital labour. Also, users maintain their communication with people by communicating with others and keeping their profiles updated. All time spent on these platforms is labour time. The prosumer commodity that advertisers buy through Facebook or Google is based on demographic data and interest-related tracks. Thus, all the time users spend on social media platforms creates the value of the prosumer commodity, namely labour time. (Fuchs, 2014: p. 115). Users generate value for the platform every time they are on these platforms. Since social media platforms are not a survival means, it turns out that users are exploited for the time they consume and the value they create on these platforms. Social media platforms are ostensibly free. However, providing only the users of these communication tools in return for the time and digital labour spent is not enough to cover up the exploitation (Fuchs, 2014: p. 89).

Method: The quantitative method was used in the field study. The field research was carried out by questionnaire technique, which is one of the quantitative research techniques, and computer-assisted telephone interview, which is one of the data collection types. The field research is prepared in the context of purpose-result clauses "Are social media platforms users in Turkey aware of the exploitation of digital labour on these platforms? What is the attitude of platform users in the face of digital labour exploitation?"

Quota random sample selection method was used for the sample selection of the survey participants. Since this research is on social media users, the research population consists of 60 million active social media users living in Turkey. The research sample through the phone lists provided by mobile phone operators for a fee. Thus, the research sample is quota as 50% female and 50% male. The final sample group in the study, in which around 400 participants we interviewed, was down to 380 after deducting the participants under the age of 14 and over the age of 54 and the participants with socioeconomic status E.

There were 50 questions in total in the questionnaire form. First five questions in the questionnaire to determine the most used social media platforms, from which device these applications are visited and how many hours a day these applications are used. The last nine questions at the end of the questionnaire are questions for collecting demographic data added to the questionnaire to make a descriptive statistical analysis of the participants. The questions from 6 to 21 aim to determine the purpose of using social media and instant messaging applications. Questions between 22 and 24 aim to determine the participants' awareness of the concept of personal data. The primary purpose of the questions numbered 25 to 33 is to determine the attitudes and awareness of the participants about the exploitation of digital labour, which is the essence of the study, which occurs through the prosumer content and data of social media and instant messaging applications. Questions between 34 and 38 to determine the respondents' awareness of the WhatsApp Privacy Policy and their attitude changes. Questions 39 to 41 are also questions aimed at reflecting the post-exploitation participants' decisions on whether to keep in social media platforms.

The ethics committee permission for the study was obtained from Istanbul University Ethics Committee of Social and Human Sciences Research in accordance with the decision dated Sep 6, 2021 and numbered 2021/160. The interviewer obtained verbal consent from the respondents. Data collection and recording took place in October 2021. A relevant statistic firm carried out reliability and validity tests, frequency and descriptive analyzes of the research with the most appropriate methods. Also, standard deviation, variance and standard error measurements were made to answer research question.

Conclusion and Suggestions: This study explained how the exploitation of digital labour by social media companies, characterized by unpaid labour-time and personal data, takes place. In the theoretical part of the study, the concepts of digital labour, digital capitalism and the prosumer commodity of social media users are discussed. In addition, Facebook's targeted advertising model was handled with Facebook's critical political economy approach, and digital labour exploitation on social media platforms was revealed. In the evaluation made of Marx's surplus-value theory, which Christian Fuchs adapted to social media, it was seen that the exploitation of prosumer labour in social media converged towards infinity. In short, it has been revealed that prosumer labour is exploited almost endlessly in social media.

According to the findings obtained in the field study that awareness of digital labour exploitation was not high. One out of every three users is unaware that they are being exploited. The tendency to quit the use of social media in the face of exploitation was determined as only one out of every five people. The rate of users who prioritize the use of social media over-exploitation and personal privacy is at a substantial level. Undoubtedly, this is the most striking result we reached in our study.

The first two motivations for using social media platforms were "staying in touch with family and friends" and "because a lot of my friends are there". Thus, it can be concluded that mobile usage has peaked and nearly half of the users see social media as a communication tool.

Another important finding in our study is that young users between the ages of 14-18 spend an average of 5.7 hours on social media and instant messaging applications. This period constitutes almost a quarter of a day. It is only 2 hours shorter than an 8-hour workday. This finding reminds us of the exploitation of child labourers working long hours in poor conditions in England, which Marx mentioned in Capital (1867).

The negative effects of social media and the attention industry can be listed as follows: digital labour exploitation, privacy violations, and socio-psychological effects (addiction, distraction, over-socialization

and depression). To cope with the exploitation of digital labour, we may choose not to use these platforms or use them less in the first place. As academicians in the field of communication, we can intensify studies on this subject to raise awareness about the exploitation of digital labour. We can talk more about this in our lessons. We need to acquire a solid critical media literacy habit to create general awareness digital labour exploitation and awareness about the harmful effects of social media. Undoubtedly, social media has beneficial aspects; but it is essential to read and teach these mediums critically, not just from a participatory culture and techno-determinist perspective because it is impossible to fix something that is getting worse without criticism.

Keywords: Communication Science, Critical Political Economy of Communication, Digital Labour, Digital Capitalism, Digital Labour Exploitation

Öz: Facebook, Instagram ve WhatsApp'ın sahibi Meta Platforms dünyanın en büyük sosyal medya şirketidir. Sosyal medya şirketlerinin gelir modeli hedefli reklamcılığa dayanmaktadır. Bu reklamcılık türünde kullanıcının sosyal medyada bıraktığı beğeni ve her türlü veri meta olarak pazarlama şirketlerine satılır. Kullanıcıların tüm zaman ve dikkatlerini platforma vermesi beklenir. Kullanıcı sayısı ne kadar artar ve platformda ne kadar zaman harcanırsa o kadar fazla kullanıcı dikkati ve verisi hasat edilebilecektir. Sosyal medya şirketlerinin sermaye birikimi gerçekleştirebilmesinin önkoşulu budur. Verilerin toplanması gizlilik politikalarıyla garanti altına alınmıştır. Sosyal medyanın sağladığı kazanımlardan vazgeçmemek adına gizlilik politikasında yazılanlar çoğu zaman umursanmaz ya da bu politikalar vakit kaybı olmasın diye kullanıcılar tarafından hiç okunmaz. Böylece verilerinin pazarlama şirketlerine satılmasına razı olurlar. Kullanıcılar sosyal medya içeriğini kendileri üretip tüketirler. Bu sırada hatırı sayılır bir emek zamanı harcarlar. Harcanan emek zamanı ve pazarlama şirketlerine meta olarak satılan verileri karşılığında kullanıcılara hiç ödeme yapılmaz. Buna dijital emek sömürüsü adı verilir. Sosyal medya platformları teoride bedavadır; fakat pratikte ödenen bedel kullanıcının sömürülmesidir. Bu çalışmada sosyal medyada karşılığı ödenmemiş kullanıcı emeği ve verisiyle karakterize olan dijital emek sömürüsünün açıklanması amaçlanmıştır. Çalışmanın kuramsal kısmında dijital emek sömürüsü Facebook'un sermaye birikim modeli esas alınarak incelenmiştir. Türkiye'deki sosyal medya kullanıcılarının dijital emek sömürüsü karşısındaki tutum ve farkındalıklarını tespit etmek amacıyla da alan araştırması gerçekleştirilmiştir. Alan araştırmasında kullanıcıların dijital emek sömürüsü karşısında farkındalıklarının yüksek olmadığı sonucuna ulaşılmıştır. Azımsanmayacak oranda kullanıcının da sosyal medyada var olmayı sömürülmenin önüne koyduğu tespit edilmiştir.

Anahtar Kelimeler: İletişim Bilimleri, İletişimin Eleştirel Ekonomi Politiği, Dijital Emek, Dijital Kapitalizm, Dijital Emek Sömürüsü

Introduction: From traditional media monopolies to new media monopolies

According to Bagdikian (2004), at the beginning of the 2000s, there were five dominant corporations operating like cartels in the media and communication industries. These five giant companies in the field of conventional communication were: Time Warner, Viacom, Walt Disney Company, News Corporation and Bertelsmann. These companies not only have a means of communication but also have a significant command of journalism, film, and media in general. Bagdikian stated that five giant companies were given "much more power of communication than a despot or dictator has." Although they operate only in the media sector among the industries that have a monopoly in the U.S. economy, they are of particular importance as they create a "social and political world" rather than a "nut and bolt".

From 2004 onwards, with the rise of Web 2.0 and user-generated content, in the internet world, which quickly got over the Dot-com crash, a new system began to sprout under the name of social media. Hence, the picture that Bagdikian draws has been replaced by five different large media companies operating in the internet and technology field. Based on market capitalization, these new media goliaths are Apple, Microsoft, Google, Amazon, and Facebook (CompaniesMarketCap, n.d.). After the 9/11 attacks in the USA, these companies were given

excessive communication and surveillance power, just like the old media monopolies (Zuboff, 2019). Unlike the big screens used by their predecessors, the answer to the questions about the social and political world created by these new companies can be found in the devices with small screens that we do not leave our side even for a moment, namely our phones, in the time we spend, our shortened attention span and our new sociality.

Apple, the largest of these companies operating in new media and technology, is a hardware and software manufacturer. Microsoft also produces hardware and software and sells licenses. The biggest online retailer, Amazon, also serves as a reliable cloud computing platform. Google, the most prominent new media company and a search engine operating in software and hardware, has servers and sells storage. It is also the owner of the world's largest video streaming platform, YouTube. Among these five companies, Facebook differs from the other companies because, as a social media company, it does not produce any hardware or software, although it has had a few unsuccessful attempts (Brodsky, 2020). The only thing Facebook sells to its customers is advertising.

While opening to the stock market in 2012, Mark Zuckerberg registered his company with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission with the following mission: "We don't build services to make money; we make money to build better services. And we think this is a good way to build something" (SEC, 2012). Zuckerberg also wrote on Facebook Newsroom in 2012: "Helping a billion people connect is amazing, humbling and by far the thing I am most proud of in my life" (Zuckerberg, 2012). Another quote from Zuckerberg interview reads: "When you give everyone a voice and give people power the system usually ends up in a really good place" (Gillis, 2010). In his Facebook status updates and interviews, Zuckerberg often puts similar emphasis on "sociality", "social benefit", "connecting people" and "goodness". In doing so, Zuckerberg tried to show that the main thing that matters for Facebook is a social benefit, not money. However, between 2007 and 2016, Facebook got into trouble with privacy violations and democracy interference. Some of these include Facebook's Beacon feature revealing user information in 2007 (Clark, 2007); Russian interference in the 2016 US presidential election via Facebook ads; Cambridge Analytica's manipulation of the Brexit vote with user data obtained from Facebook, and Cambridge Analytica's work in favour of Trump to persuade undecided voters on Facebook during the election period (Meredith, 2018). Afterwards, the “WhatsApp Privacy Policy” came to the fore (Ranipeta, 2021). Facebook obliges WhatsApp users to share their data with marketing companies with this policy. It stated that those declining this agreement would not be able to use WhatsApp (Stolyar, 2021). After the reactions, Facebook had to suspend this policy (Newman, 2021). Thus, it has been understood that the purpose of Facebook, which has grown and prospered, is to become a monopoly in the social media industry rather than connecting humanity by means of social benefit.

Changing its name to Meta Platforms in 2021 (Isaac, 2021), Facebook has evolved from a small social network on the Harvard University campus in 16 years into an oligopoly in the technology industry. Nowadays, Facebook has 2.91 billion users, and Facebook-owned Instagram has approximately 1.5 billion users. These figures make Facebook the world's largest social media company (Kemp, 2022). Today, Facebook ranks 8th among the top 10 most valuable companies in the world with 488 billion US dollars in market value (Morahan, 2022), while the founder and owner of the company, Mark Zuckerberg, is the 16th wealthiest person in the world according to Forbes, with a fortune of approximately 64,1 Billion US dollars (Forbes, n.d.).

Growing with acquisitions, monopolizing vertically and horizontally, and increasing the number of its users since the day it was founded, Facebook multiplied its revenues (McCain, 2022), although it followed a fluctuating course over time (CompaniesMarketCap, n.d.). Moreover, as explained in our study, Facebook has achieved this by harvesting its users' content, data, and attention. Those achievements of Facebook have started to be a topic of interest in communication science and new media literature.

Critical new media theorist Christian Fuchs adapted the surplus value theory of Karl Marx's Capital (1867) to the capital accumulation model of social media platforms in many of his books, primarily Digital Labour and Karl Marx (2014) and Social Media: A Critical Introduction (2017). According to Fuchs (2014; 2017), Facebook has grown and prospered by exploiting the users' unpaid labour-time. Fuchs calls it digital labour exploitation.

Within this context, our study focuses on today's largest social media company Facebook (now Meta Platforms). The study aims to reveal how the exploitation of digital labour, characterized by unpaid prosumers' labour time, is carried out on Facebook and all social media platforms. The other purpose of the study is to determine the attitudes, awareness and tendencies of social media platform users in Turkey against digital labour exploitation by social media companies through field study.

This study aims to theoretically and practically conduct an integrated and inclusive research of Turkey's most used social media platform users. In this respect, the study is significant as it aims to fill the practical gap in the country's communication literature with extensive field research.

To achieve the aims of the study, the exploitation of digital labour through unpaid prosumers' labour in social media, specifically on Facebook, will be explained based on Christian Fuchs' approach. The findings obtained from the field research carried out in the context of the study will be presented, and at the end of the study, these findings will be evaluated in the discussion and conclusion part.

Following the purpose and importance of the study, the following research questions were prepared:

RQ 1: What is the exploitation of digital labour by social media companies on social media platforms? On which platforms and how is digital labour exploitation carried out? What is the rate of exploitation?

RQ 2: What are the most used social media platforms? Do the usage rates of these platforms differ according to demographic variables?

RQ3: Do the purpose and frequency of using social media platforms differ according to demographic variables?

RQ4: What is the rate of awareness of social media users that the content produced/shared on social media is transformed into financial gain by social media companies, and what are their attitudes and approaches to this issue?

RQ5: How did the respondents' tendency to quit using social media in the face of digital labour exploitation by social media companies develop?

In the theoretical part of the study, digital labour, digital capitalism, and the prosumers commodity concepts of social media users will be discussed. Then, Facebook's targeted advertising model will be defined with the help of Facebook's critical political economy approach, and how the exploitation of digital labour on social media platforms takes place will be explained. Thus, the first research question will be answered in the theoretical part of the study. In order to answer the other four research questions, we will use field research on social media users with the help of a survey technique.

Turkish Literature

Studies in Turkey on the exploitation of digital labour on social media platforms have increased in recent years (Aytekin and Yandım, 2017; Duman and Özdoyran, 2018; Kılıç, 2019; Dağtaş and Yoldaş, 2020; Çeliker-Saraç and Aksoy, 2021; Karaca, 2021; Sim, 2021; Özdemir, 2022).

Aytekin and Yandım (2017), in their study using multiple case studies and content analysis methods, concluded that the capitalists of social media companies sell their user information, the content they produce and all their online activities to marketing companies and realize information-based exploitation. In that study, it was stated that capitalism gains a digital appearance through social networks; thus, the labour-capital contradiction could be presumed to increase even more.

Duman and Özdoyran (2018) conducted research using an in-depth interview technique with users who wrote on participating dictionary websites in Turkey. In that research, it was concluded that some users were uncomfortable working for free on social media. In that study, they found that some other users who wrote in dictionaries were not uncomfortable with working for free. That study also revealed that users viewed writing and working time on collaborative hypertext dictionary websites as entertainment rather than a job.

Kılıç (2019), in his field research for Facebook and YouTube users, tried to determine the awareness of users of this platform about whether they contribute to a commercial system. That study revealed that Facebook and YouTube users' consciousness of contributing to a commercial system is low. That study determined that Facebook and YouTube users use these platforms frequently for entertainment and see social media as a leisure activity.

Dağtaş and Yoldaş (2020), in their study using the in-depth interview technique for Twitter users, concluded that the participants see Twitter as a digital space in which production and exchange relations take place and as a tool that allows these relations to take place.

Karaca (2021), in his study, discussed Google in terms of the concept of digital labour. That study concluded that the data of digital media users are available for use by the media industry, and personalized messages are created by taking this data into account. That study also concluded that data was used to create surplus value and become the commodity of commercial organizations as unpaid labour.

Sim (2021) conducted a field study on female bloggers in Turkey. That research concluded that while women were writing blogs, they were also integrated into the neoliberal reshaping of Turkey with the global market system they entered through blogging. That research determined that although blogs provide economic gain and job opportunities, the primary motivation behind women's blogging is the impulse of self-realization and self-fulfilment by leaving the labour of hope behind.

Özdemir (2022), in his study, examined the Cambridge Analytica scandal on Facebook within the framework of concepts such as participatory culture, digital labour exploitation and privacy violation. That study concluded that although it is claimed that social media offers a free and safe communication environment to users, this environment cannot be provided in the context of scandal and that the trust in social media should be questioned.

When the Turkish communication literature is scanned, it is seen that there is a lack of comprehensive field research on the exploitation of digital labour in social media platforms, as can be understood from the studies mentioned above. Our study aims to fill this gap.

Conceptual and Theoretical Framework: Digital Labour Exploitation and Critical Political Economy of Facebook

The critical political economy of communication has particular importance in critical communication theories as it can handle mass media and new media from an integrated perspective. Before the critical analysis of Facebook, it is necessary to explain how the critical political economy of communication approach, adapted to new media studies in recent years, has emerged and developed.

In Britain in the late 18th and early 19th centuries, political economy was invented by pioneering economists such as Adam Smith, David Ricardo, and Thomas Malthus. While we know that Adam Smith was the pioneer of the liberal approach, Karl Marx opposed the liberal approach and criticized political economy and became the pioneer of critical political economy. All political economy approaches, including Marx's, which is against the liberal political economy, by addressing the issue of "power" in economy, social and political policies (Geray, 2016: p. 16).

David Harvey argues that Marx is not an analyst of structure and things but rather a thinker who ponders "processes, flows, and their relationships." According to Harvey, Marx reveals the processes that establish and sustain capitalism and " explains the explanatory and dynamic relations between the elements in the capitalist system". Marx's concepts catch the dynamic relations and contradictions that drive the change and imbalance inherent in the capitalist accumulation process (Cohen, 2019, p: 50). Thus, Marx's critique of capitalism can be adapted to any sector dominated by the capitalist economy. The structuring in the media and communication sector had turned into a capitalist structuring since the periods when neoliberal policies began to be implemented in the world. For this reason, Marx's critical theory can also mention the field of media and communication.

Based on a Marxist framework, the critical political economy of communication, which emerged in the 1960s, was focused on understanding and explaining the media's production, distribution, and consumption processes by associating them with broad economic and social processes in an integrated structure (Mosco, 1996).

The critical political economy of communication is "the study of the production, distribution and consumption of all kinds of values". The study of commodities' production, distribution and consumption constitutes this approach's economic dimension. This approach's political dimension is analysing power relations affecting this process. The symbolic aspect of the political economy of communication includes "the study of the complex relations between the control of the intellectual means of production and the ways of thinking and acting of people". In short, this approach concerns the study of all hegemonic relations in addition to material production. The structure of media ownership, labour processes in the communication industry, commodification and ideologization of media contents, developments in this field and ethical issues cover the field of study of this approach (Bulut, 2009: p. 8).

In the 1970s and 1980s, the political economy of communication was substantially renewed by analysing the media as a field of production and emphasising the productive power of the audience in producing media value as both a commodity and labour power. This renewal began with Dallas Smythe's ground-breaking work on the audience meta in 1977. Smythe (1977) argued that media companies are not content with the consumption of media content by the audience in mass communication, but also, audience attention is being sold to advertisers by media corporations. This formulation described the audience as an active participant in the political economy of communication (Fischer, 2014; p. 121).

According to Smythe (1977), all the time except when we sleep is working time in capitalism. A significant proportion of non-business work time is audience time sold to advertisers. Workers perform marketing functions for those who market the products in this time slot, which

the audience owns. Thus, they happen to rework the production and reproduction of labour power. Media content is a "free lunch " to keep audience engaged. With this approach, Smythe introduced the concept of "the audience commodity ". According to Smythe, in the ratings-based advertising type of TV, the audience is sold to advertisers as a commodity. The audience donates unpaid labour time and receives TV show content and advertising in return.

According to the arguments above, labour was spent so that the capitalist would provide surplus value. The payment in exchange for watching TV is not money; it is a TV show. It is not possible to survive by watching TV. Therefore, watching TV and getting paid cannot be the same. There is exploitation here, as all the time devoted to watching TV is surplus labour time by commercial means (Fuchs, 2014: p. 88).

The distinction between transport and communication was still forming when Marx published Capital (1867). Such a distinction was only possible with the telegraph in 1844. However, the use of the telephone as a more functional device was in the early 1880s. Marx did not live long enough to experience this and transfer his experience to his works. Marx lived and produced his writings in the Industrial Capitalism period. Following the advancement of technology and other developments that shape the course of the world, capitalism has also evolved and spread to different areas. Anthony According to Negri, now "work has much less to do with the factory". Work has left the factory and has shifted its trajectory to the communal to become a value. The prerequisites for this process have spread to society with infrastructures such as communication networks and semi-finished information systems (Negri, 1989/2006: p. 109). Additional definitions were needed to explain capitalism as the scope of the commodity expanded into the fields of information labour, digital communication technologies, and information commodities.

Vercellone (2006/2015) stated that with the historical decline of industrial capitalism, a new stage of post-industrial capitalism, also “cognitive capitalism”, has begun. Therefore, the primary basis for the valuation of capital occurs through the control and production of knowledge. In the example of Adam Smith, the needle factory played an essential role in the development of industrial capitalism. According to Vercellone, information networks, research laboratories and models that regulate the service relationship in cognitive capitalism play this role (Vercellone, 2006/2015: p. 7).

Towards the end of the 90s, the internet took the lead in the telecommunications industry. Subsequently, “digital capitalism”s production basis and control structure emerged with the transition to the market-driven framework in communication networks. According to Dan Schiller (1999), towards the millennium, networks have more directly generalized the social and cultural spectrum of the capitalist economy than ever before. The architects of digital capitalism have made it their primary goal to develop an economy-wide network that can support ever-growing intra-company and inter-company business processes. Schiller claims that the target covers everything from production planning to product engineering to accounting, advertising, banking and education.

Zuboff (2018, p: 7) has named the type of capitalism that rises with Web 2.0 and social media platforms "surveillance capitalism". Zuboff has made multiple definitions of surveillance capitalism: "A new economic order that claims human experience as free raw material for hidden commercial practices of extraction, prediction, and sales; a parasitic economic logic in which the production of goods and services is subordinated to a new global architecture of behavioural modification ". According to Zuboff, surveillance capitalism resembles a malignant mutation unprecedented in human history, determined by capitalism's concentration of wealth, knowledge and power, which forms the basic framework of the surveillance economy. She also argues that surveillance capitalism is the origin of a new instrumental force that dominates society and poses staggering challenges to market democracy.

Realizing more capital accumulation is the primary goal of social media companies. Therefore, they want to know as much as possible about the behaviour, likes and interests of their own employees and customers. This results in the surveillance of employees and consumers. The method Facebook uses is mass surveillance. It stores, compares, evaluates and sells the usage behaviour and personal data of its billions of users. Facebook's user surveillance is also personalized and individualized because its users' browsing behaviour and related fields are analysed in detail. Users are classified according to their interests on Facebook, and each user is given the opportunity to be provided with separate advertisements on an individual basis (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 276, 284).

While the labour time required to produce a physical commodity can be measured in industrial capitalism, this has changed in the types of capitalism that emerged in the post-industrial period. In addition, the production of services and the creation of intangible commodities gained importance. The type of labour spent in such production processes has been defined as "immaterial labour" by Lazzarato (1996), one of the Autonomist Marxist theorists. Marazzi (2010/2013) stated that because this concept is an oxymoron, using the term may be inaccurate as it can cause various problems. Labour is material even when it is cognitive. In addition to physical labour, mental labour is also tiring (Marazzi, 2010/2013: p. 32).

Hardt and Negri, who previously used the concept of immaterial labour, followed Marazzi's call and used the terms "affective labour" and "symbolic labour" in Empire (2000) and Multitude (2004). The concept of "digital labour" was preferred by Christian Fuchs (2014) for all types of labour that enable capitalist companies to accumulate capital and create surplus value in information and communication technologies: Slave labour in the extraction of silicon, worker labour on the assembly line in hardware production, the labour spent outsourcing the software industry in India, the overtime work of Google workers working in poor conditions in Silicon Valley, the housewifeized service labour spent by call centre workers including the prosumer labour in social media. Thus, Fuchs theorized the term of digital labour.

Fuchs (2014) states that accumulation and ideology go hand in hand: After the dot-com crash in 2000, the capitalist internet economy had to establish a new capital accumulation strategy. The reason for this is to put forward a discourse that can persuade venture capitalists who are reluctant to make new investments. The emergence of social media as a new capital accumulation model with the rise of Web 2.0 has brought with it a social media ideology: discourses such as "social media is new", "contributes to democracy", "enables participatory culture" have been introduced. In this way, the rise of a techno-determinist ideology was witnessed via the new media (Fuchs, 2014: p. 81).

Alvin Toffler (1981) divided the history of civilization into three periods and named each of these periods a "wave". The first wave covers the beginning of the agricultural revolution and the next millennium. The second wave covers the two-hundred-year period from the industrial revolution to the end of the 1970s and the beginning of the 1980s. The period coinciding with the post-industrial period of capitalism is the emergence of the Third Wave civilization. In the first wave of civilization, people mostly consumed what they produced. They were neither producers nor consumers as we know them now. They could be called the "producer-consumer" (prosumer). According to Toffler (1981), with the advent of the Third Wave civilization, the distinction between producer and consumer will disappear, and prosumer will become widespread again (Toffler, 1981: p. 11).

Toffler's concept of prosumer has gained meaning in today's internet. In Web 2.0 sites that started in 2004, the material is somehow produced by the users of those platforms. Social interaction skills have increased with Web 2.0. Thus, social media platforms have emerged. The superiority of producers over Web 1.0 brought the superiority of consumers producing with Web

2.0. In short, in Web 2.0, users produce what they consume at the same time (Ritzer, 201/2019: p. 356).

Toffler seems to herald the advent of a new form of autonomous self-production, economic and political democracy by the notion of prosumer. However, “he overlooks that prosumption is used for outsourcing work to users and consumers”. Companies reduce investment costs and labour costs thanks to prosumers. Many professions have begun to disappear. Consumers who work for free are heavily exploited. Prosumers generate surplus value that companies seize without pay and turn into profits (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 193).

Facebook and Instagram are platforms where prosumer content is the main content. Mark Zuckerberg founded Thefacebook as an intercollegiate social networking project in 2004 as a college student at Harvard. This platform was met with interest in the university and opened to other university students in the USA. Thefacebook was open to only US university students until 2006, became a company in 2006 and changed its name to Facebook. From this point on, Facebook has taken a big step in increasing the number of users by switching to an open membership structure, opening its doors to users all over the world (Arrington, 2006).

Sheryl Sandberg, a former U.S. Department of Treasury and Google employee in 2008, was appointed head of Facebook's growth operation. With Sandberg's inauguration, Facebook adopted advertising as its business model. In addition, Facebook has started to buy platforms that compete with itself or allow the company to develop its platform and services in other technological areas (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 270). In April 2012, Facebook bought the photo-sharing platform Instagram, founded in 2010, for 1 billion US dollars (Rusli, 2012).

With Sandberg's effective growth moves bearing fruit, Facebook's shares were offered to the public in May of the same year (Pepitone, 2012). By 2014, the instant messaging application WhatsApp joined Facebook in exchange for an agreement of approximately 19.4 billion US dollars (Olson, 2014). The virtual reality company Oculus was also acquired by Facebook in the same year with a $2 billion deal (Dregde, 2014). Thus, Facebook can integrate horizontally into social media (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 270).

Users who upload photos, videos and stories, wall posts and comments, browse other profiles or increase their friend count on social platforms like Facebook and Instagram create an audience commodity sold to advertisers. Unlike traditional mass media such as TV there is user-generated content on the internet as users are also the creators. Users are regularly engaged in creative activity while creating content and communities on these platforms. Thanks to the decentralized structure of the Internet, users are more active in receiving Internet content than conventional media content (Fuchs, 2020: p. 194).

Wu (2016/2020: p. 12), refers to mass media that make money through advertising as "attention merchants". Although the methods used by these companies differ, their business models are similar: They offer their products as "free" by creating a kind of attraction. Then they gather the target audience together and sell that audience's attention to the highest-paying person.

Although social media platforms are provided free of charge, these platforms cannot be excluded from the commodity form because these platforms commodify users' data. TV show content is provided to the viewer in exchange for selling the audience commodity to advertisers. Similarly, social media companies provide their users with communication tools such as Facebook, Instagram and Twitter. Social media platforms are not survival means. So, they do not function as money. On the contrary, these platforms contribute to wealth growth as they are tools that generate value and profit creation for their shareholders. “This circumstance arises from the simultaneous character of social media users as consumers of technological services and producers of data, commodities, value and profit”. Users generate value for the platform every time they are on these platforms. Since social media platforms are not a survival means, it turns out that users are

exploited for the time they consume and the value they create on these platforms. Social media platforms are ostensibly free. However, providing only the users of these communication tools in return for the time and labour spent is not enough to cover up the exploitation (Fuchs, 2014: p. 89).

Social media users are also kept under ideological control by the platform owners. Users can refuse to use social media platforms and delete their accounts there, yet this may cause users to miss some social connection opportunities. They can refuse social media use just as an employee refuses to work. However, as a result, there is a possibility of becoming socially disadvantaged in society and getting harmed. It follows that users are compelled to use social media. The greater the monopoly power of the platforms, the easier the pressure will be on those who use these platforms. Contents on Facebook and other social platforms are created by the users. They spend much labour on creating content. Users' data is sold to customers paying advertising fees to gain the attention of specifically targeted groups by being surveilled. Users cannot control their data on platforms, nor do they own them. Producing values and products belonging to someone else, the labour that constitutes the audience commodity is exploited (Fuchs, 2014: p. 91).

Apart from the distraction they create for "attention merchants" like Facebook, the amount of time we spend on their platforms is also very important. Every moment spent away from the attention industry is a significant loss for the "attention merchants". That is why "attention merchants" want to dominate our time as much as possible. Platform users are constantly subjected to temptations and occasionally overt coercion (Wu, 2016/2020: p. 15).

Since Facebook is a capitalist company, its economic purpose is to obtain financial benefits. Targeted advertising helps Facebook with this. For this purpose, advertisements are adapted to suit people's consumption habits. Social media platforms are particularly suitable for targeted advertising as they monitor data for economic purposes and also store personal likes that allow users to calculate and identify possible products they can purchase. Therefore, targeted advertising is the most profitable revenue source for social media companies. The privacy policy protects the use of targeted advertising and economic surveillance. Users must accept the privacy policy to use Facebook. In this way they consent for their data to be sold to marketing companies. Since Facebook is the most used social media platform in the world with its platforms, it is unlikely for the users to refuse to use them. Refusing to use these platforms can result in users missing social opportunities to stay in touch with friends or form new relationships. Also, people who do not use social media can be treated as strangers in most communities. Thus, Facebook compels its users to accept using personal data for economic purposes (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 284-287).

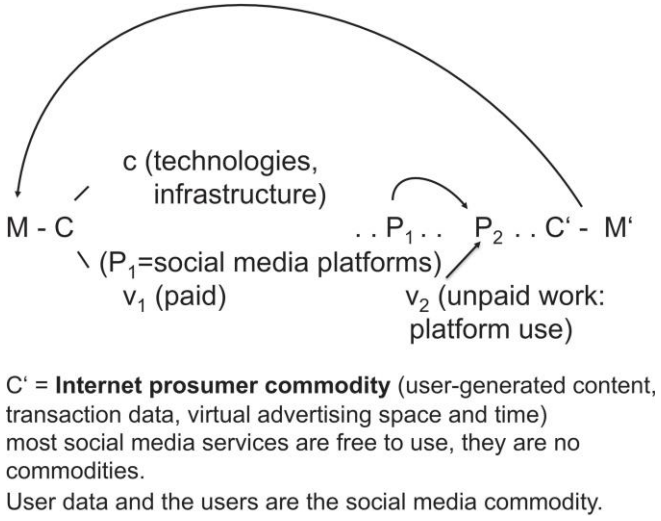


Figure 1: Capital Accumulation on Corporate Social Media Platforms That are Based on Targeted Advertising (Fuchs, 2014: p. 102)

Marx (1867) developed the theory of surplus value in Capital. This theory was later adapted by Fuchs (2014) to the process of capital accumulation in social media platforms financed by targeted advertising. The capital accumulation process in social media is shown in Figure 1:

> Social media corporations invest money (M) for buying capital: technologies (server space, computers, organizational infrastructure, etc.) and labour-power (paid employees). These are the constant capital (c), and the variable capital v1 outlays. The outcome of the production process, P1, is not a commodity that is directly sold but rather a social media service (the specific platforms) that is made available without payment to users. As a consequence of this circumstance, management literature has focused on identifying how to make profit from free Internet services. […] The waged employees, who create social media online environments that are accessed by users, produce part of the surplus value. The users employ the platform for generating content that they upload (user-generated data). The constant and variable capital invested by social media companies (c, v1) that is objectified in the online environment is the prerequisite for their activities in the production process, P2. Their products are user-generated data, personal data, social networks and transaction data about their browsing behaviour and communication behaviour on corporate social media. They invest a certain labour time, v2, in this process (Fuchs, 2014: p. 102).

Social media companies sell users' data commodities to marketing companies or advertising publishers for a price higher than the fixed and variable capital invested. The surplus value available in this sold commodity is partly created by users and partly by employees of social media companies. Users are more exploited as users are not paid, whereas employees are paid. When the prosumer data commodity is sold to the advertising customer, the commodity turns into money; surplus value turns into capital. According to Marxist theory, this is exploitation, as social media users are not paid for the content produced. This accumulation strategy pursued by social media companies is to provide users with free access to services and platforms, to allow them to produce content, and to accumulate as many prosumers as possible that can be sold as commodities to advertisers (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 199).

On social media platforms, content is created and reviewed by users. Users maintain their communication with people by communicating with others and keeping their profiles updated. All time spent on these platforms is labour time. The prosumer commodity that advertisers buy through Facebook or Google is based on demographic data and interest-related tracks. Thus, all the time users spend on social media platforms creates the value of the prosumer commodity, namely labour time. Labour time includes the time needed to manage social relationships and conduct cultural activities that build users' reputations. The reason why users use social media is the effort to reach the social, cultural and symbolic capital Bourdieu named. The user time spent on reaching them is included in the capital conversion time of the prosumer commodity (Fuchs, 2014: p. 115).

In lieu of a conclusion: In this part of our study, we tried to explain how the exploitation of digital labour in social media occurs. In response to RQ1, the exploitation of digital labour is characterized by unpaid prosumer labour on social media. By selling prosumer commodities to marketing companies, social media platforms realize capital accumulation and increase their wealth.

Marx defined the difference between workers' unpaid labour time and paid labour time as the "exploitation rate". When a worker in a factory who spends 10 hours of labour time producing a product is paid for 8 hours of work, the worker has worked 2 hours extra for the capitalist. The capitalist uses the difference to accumulate capital. The exploitation rate of the factory worker in this example is 20%. As an additional response to RQ1, the exploitation rate on social media converges to infinity as users are not paid. Thus, as Fuchs (2017/2020) delivers, prosumer labour on the internet is endlessly exploited by capitalist social media companies (Fuchs, 2017/2020: p. 200).

Method

The purpose of the field research in the study is to determine the attitudes and awareness levels of the social media platform users, who are in the position of prosumer, about digital labour exploitation and to answer the related research questions.

The quantitative method was used in the field study. The field research was carried out by questionnaire technique, which is one of the quantitative research techniques, and computer-assisted telephone interview, which is one of the data collection types.

The field research is prepared in the context of purpose-result clauses "Are social media platforms users in Turkey aware of the exploitation of digital labour on these platforms? What is the attitude of platform users in the face of digital labour exploitation?"

Research population-sample design and data collection tools

We Are Social is an agency that conducts extensive research on the use of the internet and social media. According to the 2021 internet and social media usage report published by We Are Social and Hootsuite, there are 65.8 million internet users in Turkey. 60 million internet users are also active social media users (Kemp, 2021). Since our study is a research on social media users, our research population consists of 60 million active social media users living in Turkey. We obtained -the social media users- that will make up the research sample through the phone lists provided by mobile phone operators for a fee.

A sample size of around 384 is considered sufficient for a 95% confidence level and a 5% confidence interval in a field study to be conducted on a research population consisting of a population of 60 million (Gil *et al* 2010).

Quota random sample selection method was used for the sample selection of the survey participants. According to this sample selection method, a limited universe can be classified according to certain variables predicted by the researcher in accordance with the purpose of the research (Simkus, 2022). In this context, the participants to be included in the sample must be social media users first. Considering this, only social media users were included in the research sample at first. According to Turkish Statistical Institute's 2021 data, 49.9% of the population of Turkey is female, and 50.1% is male (Turkish Statistical Institute, 2022). This study aims to be a study based on gender equality. Thus, the research sample is quota as 50% female and 50% male. Thirdly, we divided the sample group according to age groups based on the lower main generations. Users under 14 and over 54 were excluded from the sample because they did not comply with our research model and would not contribute.

Finally, people with a socioeconomic status below D - those with no income and those who are not primary school graduates- were excluded from the sample group. The final sample group in the study, in which around 400 participants we interviewed, was down to 380 after deducting the participants under the age of 14 and over the age of 54 and the participants with socioeconomic status E. Thus, the research sample took its final form.

We consulted a communication science professor and an economics professor about preparing the questionnaire questions and form. There are 50 questions in total in the questionnaire form. We designed the first five questions in the questionnaire to determine the most used social media platforms, from which device these applications are visited and how many hours a day these applications are used. The questions from 6 to 21 aim to determine the purpose of using social media and instant messaging applications. These questions were included in the survey after the Turkish translation of the research prepared and conducted by the worldwide operating mass research company GWI, which can also be found in the global internet and social media usage report published by We Are Social every year (We Are Social, 2022). Questions between 22 and 24 aim to determine the participants' awareness of the concept of personal data. The questions here

have been prepared in accordance with the Personal Data Protection Law No. 6698 in Turkey. The primary purpose of the questions numbered 25 to 33 is to determine the attitudes and awareness of the participants about the exploitation of digital labour, which is the essence of the study, which occurs through the prosumer content and data of social media and instant messaging applications. We asked questions between 34 and 38 to determine the respondents' awareness of the WhatsApp Privacy Policy and their attitude changes. Questions 39 to 41 are also questions aimed at reflecting the post-exploitation participants' decisions on whether to keep in social media and instant messaging applications.

The last nine questions at the end of the questionnaire are questions for collecting demographic data added to the questionnaire to make a descriptive statistical analysis of the participants. In these questions, the participants were asked about their age, gender, marital status, income and education status, the school they graduated from or going to, their place of work and the province of residence. We used that data to determine the participants' socio-economic status (SES). The preparation of the income question was based on July 2021 TUIK data. We used Turkish Researchers' Association socio economic status scale to determine socio economic status (Turkish Researchers' Association, 2012). We preferred CATI (Computer Aided Telephone Interview) as a data collection technique in the research. With the help of this technique, the operator/interrogator sees all of the survey questions on a computer screen, and all technical applications such as skipping questions, rotation between choices, quota and logic control and the completion time of the interview are determined in real-time, thanks to the software program used (Voxco, n.d.).

We obtained the ethics committee permission for the research from Istanbul University Ethics Committee of Social and Human Sciences Research in accordance with the decision dated Sep 6, 2021 and numbered 2021/160. The survey text was read to the participant by the operator. Also, the interviewer recorded the answers via a computer program. During the phone call, the participants' conversations were not recorded. The interviewer only saved the survey responses for transfer to Microsoft Excel. The interviewer obtained verbal consent from the respondents. The interviewer stated that the conversation would not be recorded; only the answers would be stored.

Data collection and recording took place in October 2021. The collected and recorded research data were then converted into a data set in Microsoft Excel and transferred to the IBM Statistics software SPSS 26 program. A statistic firm made the data analyses with SPSS 26 package program. This firm carried out reliability and validity tests, frequency and descriptive analyzes of the research with the most appropriate methods. Also, the questions in the questionnaire were tested by this firm at 99% (α=0.01), 95% (α=0.05) and 90% (α=0.1) confidence levels. Subsequently, the interpretation of the research findings was carried out.

Because they do not overlap with the scope and purpose of this study and cause the page and word limit to be exceeded, we decided to exclude the instant messaging application usage rates, findings about the "personal data" term and the findings about WhatsApp Privacy Policy. We saved those findings for use in a forthcoming paper.

Findings

Descriptive statistics regarding demographic data are as follows: 12.9% (f=49) of the 380 respondents who agreed to respond to the survey were 14-18 years old, 13.7% (f=52) were 19-23 years old, 52% were 4 (f=199) respondents were aged 24-44 and 21.1% (f=80) were between 45-54 years old.

As stated before, since it aims to be a study that reflects gender equality, the gender of the respondents was distributed as 50% (f=190) male and 50% (f=190) female. The marital status distribution is 47.1% (f=179) single, 52.4% (f=199) married, and 0.5% (f=2) other.

Income status of the respondents: No income 24.5% (f=93), 17.6% below 3000 TL (f=67), between 3001 – 5000 TL 26.3% (f=100), between 5001 – 7000 TL 12.6% (f=48), 7001 – 9000 TL 3.9% (f=15), 9001 TL above 4.5% (f=17), non-responders 10.5% (f=40).

19.2% (f=73) of the respondents were primary school, 36.3% (f=138) high school, 11.6% (f=44) associate degree, 25.3% (f= 96) have undergraduate, 7.4% (f=28) graduate, and 0.3% (f=1) doctorate.

Among the provinces where the respondents reside, the ten provinces with the highest participation are Istanbul 19.7% (f=75), Ankara 7.1% (f=27), İzmir 5.3% (f=20), Bursa 5% (f= 19), Kocaeli 5% (f=19), Adana 4.7% (f=18), Şanlıurfa 4.5% (f=17), Antalya 3.9% (f=15), Hatay 3.9% (f=15), Aydın 3.7% (f=14).

Finally, the socio-economic status distribution of the respondents A SES 9.2% (f=35), B SES 21.6% (f=82), C1 SES 13.4% (f=51), C2 SES 44.2% (f=168), DE SES 11.6% (f=44). It can be said that approximately one out of every three participants (30.8%) has a high socio-economic status.

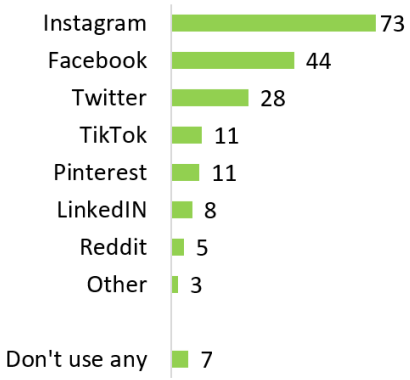
Respondents stated that they accessed social media platforms mostly via smartphone with 95.8% (f=364). The smartphone was followed by a computer with 2.4% (f=9).

Findings on responding research questions

Descriptive statistics methods, summary measures, median analysis and variable measurements were applied to the data obtained from the survey study. Standard deviation, variance and standard error measurements were made.

Respondents were asked questions about which social media platform they used the most and how many hours they spent on average per day on these social media platforms (Q2-Q3). 93.4% (f=355) of the 380 respondents stated that they use social media platforms. The findings regarding the usage rates of social media platforms by demographic variables such as gender, age, education level and socio-economic status and the average time spent on these platforms per day are as follows:

According to We Are Social's 2021 report, the most used social media platforms in the world are Facebook and Instagram. These were followed by TikTok, Pinterest, Reddit and Twitter, respectively. According to the same report, although the most used social media platforms in Turkey are Facebook and Instagram, the use of Instagram is slightly more common than Facebook. After these platforms, the most used social platforms in Turkey are Twitter, Pinterest, LinkedIn, TikTok, Tumblr and Reddit.

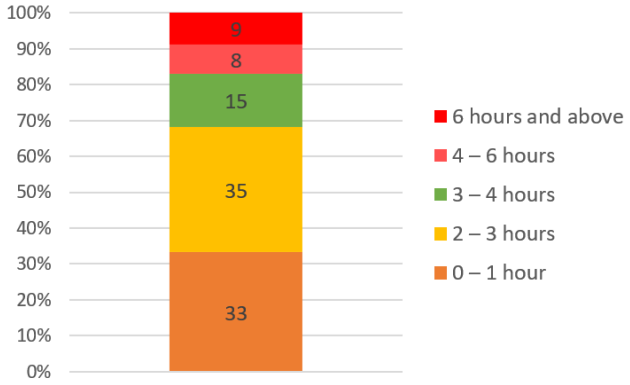


Graph 1: Ratios of Social Media Platforms Used (%)

In our study, the respondents were asked which social media platforms they used in a way that they could give more than one answer. The analysis found that an average of 1.8 social media platforms were used among the respondents. The first two most used social media platforms among 355 (93.4%) respondents who stated that they use social media platforms are Instagram and Facebook (Graph 1).

Based on the gender demographic variable, while an average of 2.1 social media platforms are used among male respondents, this figure declines to an average of 1.6 social media platforms among female respondents. While the use of Instagram is more common among female respondents (78% of women, 68% of men), among male respondents, the use of Facebook, Twitter, Tiktok, Reddit, and LinkedIn is more prominent than women respondents.

We observed that as the age group of the respondents gets younger and the level of education increases, the use of Instagram becomes more common among single respondents. The use of Facebook is higher among respondents over 45 years old and married respondents. One out of every three respondents over the age of 45 uses Facebook. The use of Facebook by young respondents between the ages of 14-23 decreases to one out of every four people. Twitter use is higher among respondents from EU socio-economic status and respondents with a university degree compared to respondents from other segments.



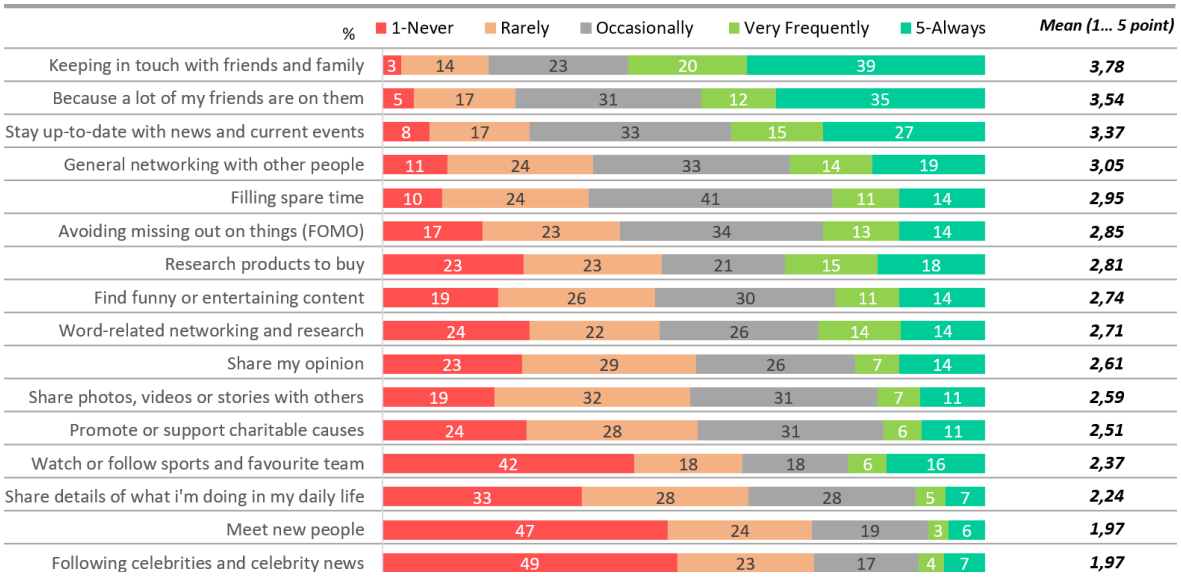
Graph 2: Average Hours Per Day Spent on Social Media Platforms

Graph 2 shows the percentage distribution of the average hours spent on social media by 355 respondents who stated that they use social media. When the average number of hours a day spent by respondents on social media is taken on account, the result is an average of 2 hours and 58 minutes per day.

Just over a third of the respondents (35%) stated that they spend an average of 2-3 hours a day on social media. One-third of the respondents (33%) stated that they spend 0-1 hour a day, 15% 3-4 hours, 8% 4-6 hours, and 9% spend 6 hours or more on social platforms.

While the use of social media platforms is an average of 3.2 hours a day for teenagers aged 14-18, the time spent on social media for those aged 45 and over decreases to an average of 2 hours a day.

Our findings revealed that the most used social media platforms and their usage rates in response to RQ2 differ according to demographic variables.



Graph 3: Purpose of Using Social Media Platforms

Graph 3 shows for what purpose (a total of 16 goals) and how often respondents use social media platforms. Accordingly, 39% of the respondents always use social media platforms primarily for "keeping in touch with friends and family". Thus, more than one-third of the respondents' highest motivation for using social media is staying in contact with friends and family.

An interesting finding we found in this part of the study that 35% of respondents stated that they use social media platforms "because a lot of my friends are on them." In this context, respondents may feel obligated to use social media just because their friends use social media platforms.

Half of the respondents answering "Following celebrities and celebrity news" (49%) and "meet new people" (47%) stated that they have never used social media platforms for this purpose. Thus, we can say that these goals constitute the lowest motivation for use of social media.

Based on the gender demographic variable, among the reasons for using social media platforms, "keeping in touch with friends and family" is higher among the female participants with %68 than the male respondents.

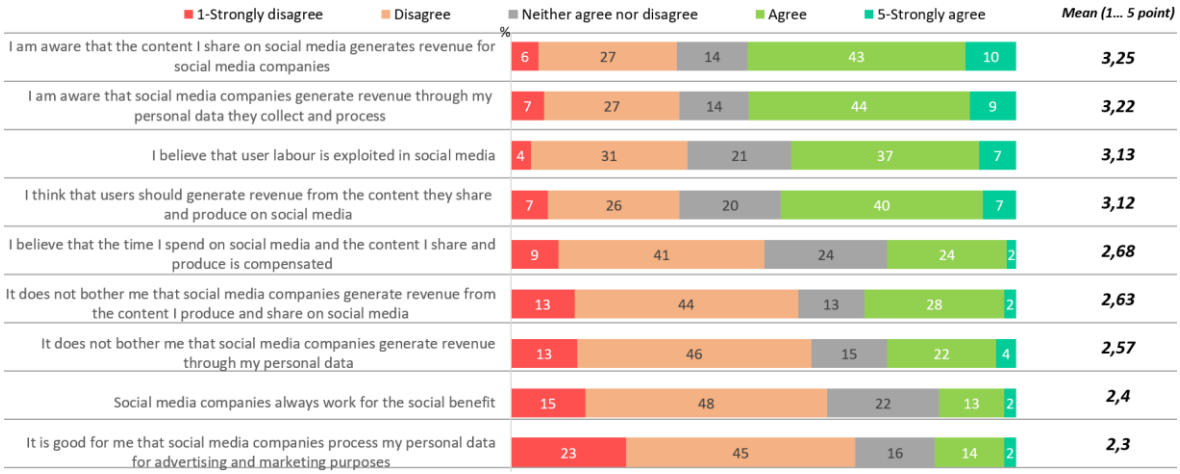
While the use of social media among female respondents "stay up-to-date with news and current events" is higher, among the male respondents, "watch or follow sports and favourite team" is higher than female respondents. Thus, we can consider that female respondents attach more importance to news and current events on social media, whereas male respondents follow sports and their favourite teams.

Based on the demographic variable of age, this rate rises to 76% in young respondents aged 14-23. When compared to other age groups, it can be said that three out of four young respondents' primary motivation for using social media is to stay in touch with their friends and families. Based on the demographic variable of education level, 70% of university graduate respondents use social media for "keeping in touch with friends and family".

As a result of the above findings, it has been revealed that the purpose and frequency of using social media platforms in response to RQ3 vary according to demographic variables.

Nine questions (Q25-Q33) regarding the exploitation of social media companies were asked to all interviewees (f=380). In these questions, the respondents were asked about their awareness of digital labour exploitation, their attitudes towards social media companies, whether

they are uncomfortable with exploitation etc. This part of the questionnaire is the essence of the study. The findings obtained from the analysis of the answers given by the respondents are as follows:



Graph 4: Respondents' Awareness and Attitudes Towards Social Media Companies

Graph 4 shows the distribution of answers to the questions explained above. Accordingly, more than half of the respondents (53%) stated that they are aware that the content they produce/share on social media turns revenue for social media companies, and social media companies generate revenue via collected-processed users' data. We found that one out of every three respondents (33%) had low awareness of these two questions. When the education variable is taken into account, the rate of agreeing with this idea increases among the respondents who are high school graduates and above. Likewise, when SES demographic variable is taken into account, this rate also increases among respondents with AB socio-economic status. As the education and socio-economic status increase, it is seen that the awareness of the respondents that the content they produce/share on social media and personal data collected by social media companies turned into revenue by social media companies.

While nearly half of the respondents (44%) believed that the effort they spent on social media was exploited, 35% of the respondents expressed the opposite opinion. Thus, one out of every two respondents argued that there is exploitation in social media, whereas one out of every three respondents disagreed that there is exploitation in social media. 21% of the respondents stated they neither agree nor disagree on this issue. We understood from the findings that the respondents' awareness of the exploitation carried out by their companies on social media is not very high. In order for a high awareness to be mentioned, it is expected that at least 67% and above (two out of three respondents) should agree on the subject of exploitation.

The rate of respondents agreeing that users should earn money from the content they share/produce on social media is 47%. Approximately one out of every two respondents thinks that payment should be gained for the content they create and share on social media. It has been determined that male respondents, based on the gender demographic variable, and respondents with EU socio-economic status, based on the SES demographic variable, have a higher rate of agreeing with this view compared to other segments.

Half of the respondents (50%) stated that they disagreed that the time they spent on social media and the content they shared and produced were compensated. While one out of every four respondents (24%) neither agree nor disagree on this issue, one out of every four (26%) believes they get their money's worth for the time and labour they spend on social media. Here, it can be

inferred that half of the respondents think that they waste their time on social media. However, more specific research is needed for this.

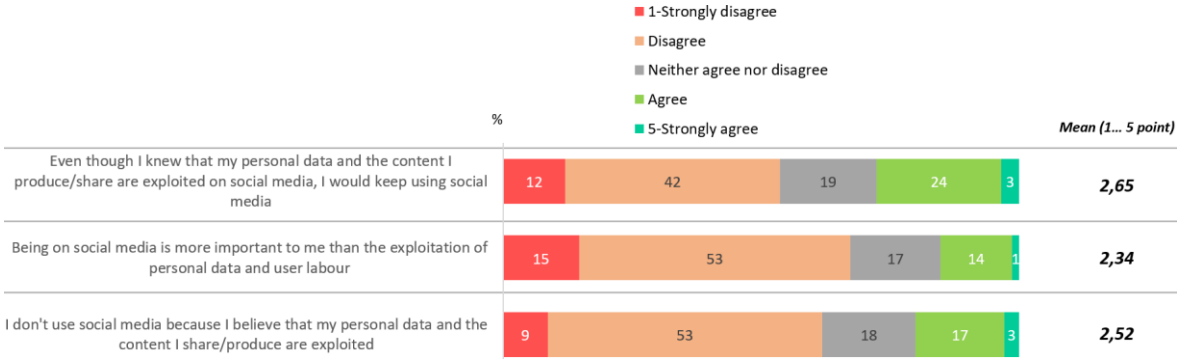
More than half of the respondents (59%) stated that it bothers them that social media companies make financial gains from the content they produce and share on social media. One out of every four respondents (26%) stated that they were not bothered by it. Based on the demographic variable of age, it has been revealed that 49% of the respondents aged 14-18 are not bothered about the financial gains of social media companies from the content produced and shared on social media. This indicates that awareness of digital labour exploitation is low among adolescent respondents.

The rate of respondents who disagree that social media companies always work for the benefit of society is 63%. From these findings, it can be estimated that two out of every three respondents see social media as a commercial medium rather than a structure operating for the benefit of society.

68% of the respondents (one out of three) stated that they disagree that processing personal data on social media for advertising and marketing purposes is a good thing.

From the above findings, it was revealed that respondents' awareness of the revenue model of social media companies is not very high (53%) in response to AS4. In addition, it was concluded that the rate (59%) of respondents were slightly more uncomfortable with social media companies monetizing personal data and content shared on social media. Moreover, one out of every two respondents (50%) stated that their time and labour on social media could not be compensated.

In the last part of the questionnaire, three questions were asked to the respondents to determine their tendency to continue/quit using social media in the face of exploitation in social media (Q39-Q41). Graph 5 shows the distribution of answers to these questions.



Graph 5: Distribution of Responses Regarding the Tendency to Continue/Quit Social Media

Approximately one-third of the respondents (27%) stated that they would continue using social media even though they knew that their personal data and the content they shared/produced were exploited. Based on the demographic variable of "age", the rate of young respondents aged 19-23 to continue using social media despite exploitation increases to 38%, while this rate decreases to 21% for respondents over the age of 45. Approximately one out of every two respondents (54%) stated that they might not keep using social media when they are aware of being exploited.

When asked whether being on social media is more important than the exploitation of personal data and user labour, nearly two out of three respondents (68%) stated that they believe personal data and effort are more important than being on social media. The rate of respondents

who disagree with this view is 15%. For this 15%, being on social media is more important than being exploited.

Based on the gender demographic variable, this rate increases to 20% for male respondents (one out of every five) and decreases to 10% for female respondents. Thus, it can be said that female respondents are more against exploitation.

The rate of respondents stating that they do not use social media because they believe that their personal data and the content shared/produced are exploited on social media is 20%.

In response to QR5, the tendency to quit using social media in the face of digital labour exploitation was neither low nor high (54%). The rate of respondents stating that they will continue to use social media despite being exploited is at a substantial level (27%). A relatively small percentage (15%) of respondents agree to be exploited, waive their privacy and declare to keep being present on social media.

Conclusion, discussion and suggestions

In this study, we explained how the exploitation of digital labour by social media companies, characterized by unpaid labour-time and personal data, takes place. In the theoretical part of the study, the concepts of digital labour, digital capitalism and the prosumer commodity of social media users are discussed. In addition, Facebook's targeted advertising model was handled with Facebook's critical political economy approach, and digital labour exploitation on social media platforms was revealed. In the evaluation made of Marx's surplus-value theory, which Christian Fuchs adapted to social media, it was seen that the exploitation of prosumer labour in social media converged towards infinity. In short, it has been revealed that prosumer labour is exploited almost endlessly in social media.

According to the findings obtained in the field study conducted to analyse the perception of digital labour exploitation in social media, it was concluded that awareness of digital labour exploitation was not high (44%). One out of every three users is unaware that they are being exploited. The tendency to quit the use of social media in the face of exploitation was determined as only one out of every five people. The rate of users who prioritize the use of social media over-exploitation and personal privacy is at a substantial level. Undoubtedly, this is the most striking result we reached in our study.

It can be said that the awareness of social media users, who constitute our study's sample, against digital labour exploitation is in line with the findings of Kılıç's (2019) study.

In our study, in which it was determined that the dominance of accessing social media platforms from smartphones was close to 100%, the first two motivations for using social media platforms were "staying in touch with family and friends" and "because a lot of my friends are there". Thus, it can be concluded that mobile usage has peaked and nearly half of the users see social media as a communication tool. In addition, the second motivation for using" because a lot of my friends are on them " may refer to the concepts of "network effect" and "network pushiness", which may be the subject of other studies.

Another important finding in our study is that young users between the ages of 14-18 spend an average of 5.7 hours on social media and instant messaging applications. This period constitutes almost a quarter of a day. It is only 2 hours shorter than an 8-hour workday. This finding reminds us of the exploitation of child labourers working long hours in poor conditions in England, which Marx mentioned in Capital (1867). In the burgeoning years of capitalism, child labourers were employed illegally by factory owners to obtain surplus value. Today's child social media labourers are not even aware that social media companies are working for their employers and producing surplus value.

Today's people in the dominance of "attention industry" and "attention merchants" who spend lots of time on social media and are constantly bombarded with notifications are the least able to maintain their attention in the history of humanity, as they feel compelled to check their electronic devices frequently. For this reason, today's human is called "homo distractus ". Every time we pick up our phone to browse our social media accounts, we wonder how all that time is lost after the attractive click baits (Wu, 2016/2020: p. 15). Newport (2019/2019) explains the answer to the above question with addiction and behaviour change.

According to Newport (2019/2019), those who produce and design social media encourage behavioural addiction by using "intermittent positive reinforcement" and "the drive for social approval". Our brain is susceptible to these two effects. Most social media platforms that push people to look at their phones or computers incessantly use these two effects to make themselves almost irresistible. Social media platforms are designed in a way similar to the working logic of a casino machine. Every tempting title and every intriguing link we see in a new tab is like pulling the lever on a slot machine. The technology industry exploits people not only in terms of digital labour, as we have explained in our study, but also in terms of getting psychological approval. Social media is tuned to provide a rich stream of information about how much or little our friends think of us. Based on these examples, we can see that social media is designed to trigger addictive behaviour.

Aral (2020/2020: p. 38) called Facebook "the hype machine "; and the new era created by Facebook and social media the "new social age". Aral (2020/2020) also stated that the new social age is transformative in the negative sense: Social media over-socializes our society increases mass persuasion, and imposes the domination of agendas. The attention economy causes behavioural changes at the population scale.

There is no doubt that smartphones and social media platforms are not as innocent as they were when they first appeared. It is not because they are lazy that people are slaves to screens; billions of dollars of investments are made by venture capitalists on these platforms. Newport (2019/2019) states that we are pushed to such a digital life not by consent but by force. He states that this is the work of the attention industry and expensive device manufacturers who have discovered the great wealth that can be obtained from a culture dominated by device and application manufacturers.

Today, the negative effects of social media and the attention industry can be listed as follows: digital labour exploitation, privacy violations, and socio-psychological effects (addiction, distraction, over-socialization and depression). So, is it possible to cope with all these negative effects? Although each has answers separately, in this study, answers can be given as suggestions at most.

To cope with the exploitation of digital labour, we may choose not to use these platforms or use them less in the first place. As academicians in the field of communication, we can intensify studies on this subject to raise awareness about the exploitation of digital labour. We can talk more about this in our lessons. Fuchs (2017/2020) also believes that alternative platforms such as Wikipedia can proliferate instead of commercial social media platforms. If possible, alternatives can be used instead of commercial social media platforms.

Regarding privacy violations, according to Aral (2020/2020), there is a need for laws protecting privacy all over the world and especially in the USA, where the laws are lax. Regarding privacy, Aral secondly states that social media users should be authorized by social media companies to control, edit and delete their personal data.

Newport (2019/2019) has important suggestions for dealing with addiction and distraction. Newport proposes a philosophy of technology use, which he calls Digital Minimalism, in which we focus our online time on the few activities that benefit what we value and which we meticulously

identify and optimize and turn our minds to the rest with peace of mind. Adopting this philosophy, digital minimalists scrupulously avoid low-value activities that ultimately bring their time and attention to more harm than good. They do not mind missing out on the little things. These people are primarily concerned about the damage to the great things that they are sure to have made their lives better. The most important thing digital minimalists do is turn technological innovations from being a source of distraction into tools to support quality life. Thus, the spell of the screens that enslave us is broken. Newport also recommends voluntary solitude. He states that on the eve of important decisions or a creative process, at least for a while, living a minimal life in digital matters and being alone voluntarily will relieve us psychologically and increase our creativity as it will reduce the distraction of a healthy mind.

Undoubtedly, we need the studies of psychology and psychiatry about social media-triggered suicide cases, anxiety and psychiatric diseases, including OCD.

Finally, we need to acquire a solid critical media literacy habit to create general awareness digital labour exploitation and awareness about the harmful effects of social media. Undoubtedly, social media has beneficial aspects; but it is essential to read and teach these mediums critically, not just from a participatory culture and techno-determinist perspective because it is impossible to fix something that is getting worse without criticism.

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